



process while acting for a corporation, is liable to be prosecuted. The law is aimed at anyone representing an organisation, such as an employee or accounting agent, as well as at individual taxpayers.

Intellectual property law

Companies doing business in the UK can apply to the Intellectual Property Office (IPO) to register intellectual property. Intellectual property includes trademarks such as product names; jingles and logos; registered designs (that is, the appearance of a product, including its packaging, pattern, and shape); and patents, which are applicable to inventions and products such as machines and medicines.

Copyright of written works, films, photography, music, web content, and sound recordings are automatically covered under UK law, as are design rights, which refer to the shape of objects and how their different parts are arranged together.

After the UK withdraws from the European Union, UK companies will still be able to register an EU trademark or a design, and UK businesses will still be able to apply to the European Patent Office for protection. Companies that have made an international patent application can apply to have this registered in the UK as well, so long as application is made within 31 months of the international application.

Corporation tax rates

The main rate of corporation tax was set at 20 per cent until 2016, but in the Budget of 2016, the government announced that the rate would change to 19 per cent for the tax years (beginning 1 April) of 2017, 2018, and 2019, and that on 1 April 2020, it would drop to 17 per cent. This rate applies to all companies except for those that profit from oil extraction or oil rights in the UK (known as ring-fence companies).

TAX SUBMISSION

The accounting year

Every year, limited companies must submit annual accounts to Companies House, and a company tax return to HMRC. For new companies, the first accounting year starts at the end of the first month of incorporation. This is called the Accounting Reference Date (ARD). The deadline for filing accounts is 21 months after the ARD for private companies, and 18 months after the ARD for public limited companies (plcs).

Deadlines for filing

Action	Deadline
Filing first accounts with Companies House	21 months after registration with Companies House
Filing annual accounts with Companies House	9 months after the company's financial year ends
Paying corporation tax, or informing HMRC that the limited company doesn't owe any corporation tax	9 months and 1 day after the company's accounting period for corporation tax ends
Filing a company tax return	12 months after the company's accounting period for corporation tax ends